# Employee Handbook

Meridian Freight Co. · Version 4.2 · Effective January 1, 2026 · Owner: People & Culture (HR)

## 1. Welcome to Meridian

Meridian Freight Co. moves goods for more than 1,100 business customers across the Midwest. We were founded in 2009 in Columbus, Ohio, with two trucks and a rented loading dock. Today we employ around 640 people across our head office in Columbus and our three warehouses in Columbus, Louisville and Indianapolis.

This handbook explains how we work together: your hours, your time off, your pay and benefits, and what we expect from each other. It applies to all employees in the United States. Where a local law gives you more rights than this handbook, the law wins. If something is unclear, ask your manager or write to People & Culture at hr@meridianfreight.example.

The handbook does not create a contract of employment. We review it every year and announce changes on the intranet at least 30 days before they take effect.

## 2. Employment basics

### 2.1 Probation period

Every new employee starts with a probation period of 90 calendar days. During probation your manager meets with you at least every two weeks to give feedback. At the end of probation you receive a short written review. Probation can be extended once, by up to 30 days, if both you and your manager agree that more time is needed.

### 2.2 Employment categories

| Category | Definition |
|---|---|
| Full-time | Scheduled for 40 hours per week |
| Part-time | Scheduled for at least 20 and fewer than 40 hours per week |
| Seasonal | Hired for a fixed period, usually October to January, for the peak season |

Seasonal employees receive pay, overtime and sick leave as described in this handbook, but are not eligible for paid time off, parental leave or the learning budget.

### 2.3 Working hours

Office hours at the head office are 8:30 AM to 5:00 PM, Monday to Friday, with a one-hour lunch break. Warehouse teams work in three shifts:

| Shift | Hours | Shift premium |
|---|---|---|
| Early | 6:00 AM – 2:30 PM | None |
| Late | 2:00 PM – 10:30 PM | $1.50 per hour |
| Night | 10:00 PM – 6:30 AM | $2.75 per hour |

Shift schedules are published in ShiftBoard at least 14 days in advance. Shift swaps between colleagues are allowed when both employees hold the same certifications and the shift supervisor approves the swap in ShiftBoard before the shift begins.

### 2.4 Recording your time

Hourly employees clock in and out at the warehouse terminals. Salaried office employees submit a weekly timesheet in ShiftBoard by 3:00 PM every Friday. Timesheets submitted late are paid in the next pay cycle.

## 3. Remote and hybrid work

We believe good work can happen anywhere, but logistics is a team sport. Our hybrid model balances flexibility with time together.

### 3.1 Who can work remotely

Office-based employees may work remotely up to two days per week once they have completed their probation period. Warehouse, driver and facilities roles require physical presence and are not eligible for remote work. Your manager may ask you to come in on a remote day for training, a customer visit or an urgent operational need, with at least 24 hours of notice.

### 3.2 Team day and core hours

Tuesday is our team day: all office-based employees work from the office on Tuesdays. On remote days you must be reachable during our core hours, 10:00 AM to 3:00 PM Eastern Time, on Teams and by phone. You may choose your other remote day freely, including Mondays and Fridays, as long as your team keeps at least one person in the office each working day.

### 3.3 Working from abroad

You may work from another country for up to 10 working days per calendar year. Requests must be approved by People & Culture at least three weeks before you travel, because tax and immigration rules differ by country. You must also inform IT before you go (see the IT & Security Policy, section 4.3). Working from abroad is not allowed during your probation period.

### 3.4 Home office support

Eligible remote employees receive a one-time home office allowance of $300 for a chair, desk or monitor, and a monthly internet allowance of $40, paid with your salary. Keep receipts for the one-time allowance and submit them in Expensely within 60 days of purchase.

## 4. Paid time off (PTO)

### 4.1 How much PTO you receive

Full-time employees earn paid time off based on their years of service:

| Years of service | PTO days per year |
|---|---|
| Less than 2 years | 15 days |
| 2 to 5 years | 20 days |
| More than 5 years | 25 days |

Part-time employees earn PTO in proportion to their scheduled hours. For example, an employee scheduled for 24 hours per week earns 60% of the full-time amount. PTO is earned monthly and can be used as soon as it is earned, including during probation.

### 4.2 Requesting time off

Request PTO in ShiftBoard. For absences of three or more consecutive working days, submit your request at least two weeks in advance. Warehouse employees should avoid requesting PTO during the peak season from November 15 to December 31; requests in this period are approved only when the team's staffing plan allows it.

### 4.3 Carrying PTO over

You may carry over up to 5 unused PTO days into the next calendar year. Carried-over days must be used by March 31; any carried-over days not used by then are lost. Unused days beyond the 5-day limit expire on December 31 and are not paid out, except when you leave the company (see section 13).

### 4.4 Company holidays

The head office closes on the following 10 paid holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Memorial Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day, the day after Thanksgiving, Christmas Eve and Christmas Day. In addition, every employee receives one floating holiday per year, which can be used for any day of personal or cultural significance.

Warehouses operate on some company holidays. Employees who work on a company holiday are paid double time for the hours worked and may take another day off within 60 days.

## 5. Sick leave

All employees, including seasonal employees, receive 10 paid sick days per calendar year. Sick days do not carry over and are not paid out when you leave. Sick days may also be used to care for a sick child, spouse or parent, or for medical appointments.

If you are sick, tell your manager before the start of your working day. Warehouse employees must call the shift supervisor at least two hours before their shift starts, so that the shift can be covered. A doctor's note is required if you are absent for more than three consecutive working days.

If you are sick for longer than your paid sick days, you may use PTO or apply for short-term disability insurance, which pays 60% of your base salary for up to 26 weeks after a 7-day waiting period.

## 6. Parental leave

Employees with at least six months of service are eligible for paid parental leave after the birth or adoption of a child:

| Situation | Paid leave |
|---|---|
| Birthing parent | 16 weeks at full pay |
| Non-birthing parent | 8 weeks at full pay |
| Adoption or foster placement (each parent) | 8 weeks at full pay |

Parental leave must be taken within 12 months of the birth or placement and may be split into a maximum of two blocks. Please tell People & Culture at least 30 days before your leave starts when possible. After parental leave, you may return on a reduced schedule of 80% of your usual hours for up to 8 weeks, at full pay.

## 7. Other types of leave

- **Bereavement leave:** up to 5 paid days after the death of an immediate family member (spouse or partner, child, parent, sibling), and up to 2 paid days for other relatives.
- **Jury duty:** paid at your full salary for the duration of your service. Please share the court summons with your manager as soon as you receive it.
- **Volunteer day:** one paid day per year to volunteer for a registered non-profit organization.
- **Moving day:** one paid day when you move to a new home, once per calendar year.
- **Military leave:** unpaid leave as required by federal and state law, with the difference between military pay and your base salary paid by the company for up to 30 days per year.

## 8. Pay

Employees are paid every two weeks, on Fridays, by direct deposit. Pay statements are available in the Payroll portal. If a payday falls on a holiday, you are paid on the previous working day.

### 8.1 Overtime

Hourly employees are paid 1.5 times their hourly rate for hours worked beyond 40 in a week, and 2 times their hourly rate for hours worked on a company holiday. Overtime must be approved by your supervisor in advance, except in emergencies. Salaried employees are not eligible for overtime pay.

### 8.2 Pay reviews

Salaries are reviewed once a year after the December performance review. Pay increases take effect on April 1.

## 9. Benefits

### 9.1 Health insurance

Medical, dental and vision coverage begins on the first day of the month after your start date. If you start on the first day of a month, coverage begins that same day. Meridian pays 80% of the premium for employee coverage and 60% of the premium for dependents. You can enroll or change your plan within 30 days of starting, during open enrollment in November, or within 30 days of a life event such as marriage or the birth of a child.

### 9.2 Retirement

Employees may join the 401(k) plan from their first day. Meridian matches 100% of your contributions up to 4% of your salary. Company contributions vest immediately, which means they belong to you from day one.

### 9.3 Learning and wellbeing

| Benefit | Amount | How to claim |
|---|---|---|
| Learning budget | $1,200 per calendar year | Pre-approval from your manager, then Expensely |
| Gym or fitness reimbursement | Up to $35 per month | Monthly in Expensely |
| Employee assistance program | 6 free counseling sessions per issue | Call the EAP line, confidential |
| Commuter benefit | Up to $120 per month pre-tax | Payroll portal |

The learning budget covers courses, certifications, conferences and books related to your current or future role. Unused learning budget does not carry over to the next year. If you leave within 12 months of completing a course that cost more than $800, you may be asked to repay part of it.

### 9.4 Employee referrals

If you refer a candidate who is hired, you receive a referral bonus of $1,500 for office roles and $750 for warehouse and driver roles. The bonus is paid once the new employee has completed 90 days of employment. Managers referring candidates for their own team are not eligible.

## 10. Expenses and business travel

We reimburse reasonable expenses you pay for while doing your job. Submit all expenses in Expensely within 30 days of the purchase. A receipt is required for any expense over $25. Expenses submitted more than 90 days late will not be reimbursed.

### 10.1 Travel limits

| Item | Limit |
|---|---|
| Meals (per diem) | $60 per day in the US, $85 per day abroad |
| Hotel | Up to $220 per night; up to $300 per night in New York, San Francisco and Boston |
| Flights | Economy class for flights under 6 hours; premium economy for flights of 6 hours or more |
| Personal car | 67 cents per mile, plus parking and tolls |
| Rental car | Compact or midsize class, booked through the travel portal |

Book flights and hotels through the company travel portal at least 14 days in advance when possible. Alcohol is not reimbursed, except as part of approved client entertainment.

### 10.2 Client entertainment

Client meals and events are reimbursed when they have a clear business purpose. Any client entertainment above $250 in total requires approval from a director before the event. Record the names of the guests and their companies in Expensely.

### 10.3 Corporate cards

Employees who travel more than four times per year can request a corporate card. The corporate card must not be used for personal purchases, even if you plan to pay them back.

## 11. Company equipment

Office employees receive a laptop, a headset and a phone if their role requires one. Laptops are replaced every three years. Employees in on-call roles receive a phone allowance of $50 per month instead of a company phone.

If your laptop or phone is lost or stolen, report it to the IT Service Desk immediately, and in any case within 24 hours, so the device can be locked remotely. You may be asked to pay up to $250 toward a replacement if the loss was caused by clear negligence, such as leaving the laptop visible in an unlocked car.

## 12. Conduct and safety

### 12.1 Dress code

The dress code at the head office is business casual. In the warehouses, safety boots and a high-visibility vest are required at all times on the warehouse floor. Safety glasses are also required in Zone B (packaging and strapping).

### 12.2 Gifts and conflicts of interest

You may accept gifts from customers or suppliers worth up to $75 per year from any one company. Cash and gift cards may never be accepted. If you have a personal relationship or financial interest that could affect your decisions at work, disclose it to People & Culture using the conflict of interest form.

### 12.3 Reporting concerns

We do not tolerate harassment, discrimination or retaliation. Report concerns to your manager, to People & Culture, or anonymously through the EthicsLine at 1-800-555-0142 or ethics@meridianfreight.example. The EthicsLine is run by an independent provider and is available 24 hours a day.

### 12.4 Workplace safety

Only certified employees may operate forklifts and pallet jacks. Forklift certification is provided by Meridian and must be renewed every three years. Report any injury, however small, to your supervisor within 24 hours, and report near misses through the Safety app. Smoking and vaping are allowed only in the marked areas outside each building.

## 13. Performance and leaving the company

### 13.1 Performance reviews

Performance reviews take place twice a year, in June and December. The December review is used for pay reviews and promotions. Promotions are announced in March.

### 13.2 Resigning

If you decide to leave, please give at least two weeks of written notice. Managers and directors are asked to give four weeks of notice. Unused PTO earned in the current year is paid out in your final paycheck; sick days are not paid out.

Return your laptop, badge, phone and any other company property within 5 working days of your last day. You will be invited to an optional exit interview with People & Culture. Former employees who left in good standing are welcome to apply again; their years of service are restored if they return within 12 months.